# Scratch and Dent Dreams and Angelic Insanity

By Eric Darby and Kevin "Chesko" Briancesco

## INTRODUCTION

*We all had childhood dreams. Many of us wanted to be astronauts, painters, actors, firefighters, lawyers, doctors or perhaps even the president. Indeed, the magical brain of a child perceives the world as an endless array of possibilities. But somewhere along the way, we lose the ability to dream . . . to imagine . . . to live life with a sense of wonder and we get bogged down in the Here and Now, the daily grind, the REALITY of our situations.*

*Well today, just for a few minutes, cast your adult reality aside and instead reach with "Angelic Insanity" for some of those lost, "Scratch and Dent Dreams." by Eric Darby and Kevin "Chesko" Brianesco.*

### Scratch and Dent Dreams by Eric Darby

Come on in, I've got a sale on scratch and dent dreams -
whole cases of imperfect ambitions
stuff the Idealists couldn't sell.
Yeah, I know none of its got price tags -
you decide how much its worth.

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An' none of it's got glossy colored packaging
but it all works just fine.
I've got rainy day swing sets, good night kisses,
and stationary stars still flying at the speed of light.

Over there in back,
if you dig down through the alabaster stoplights
and those old 45's
you'll find a whole crate of second-hand hope.
Yeah! That's real chrome - you just gotta
polish it up a little bit.
Most folks give up too easy, trade it in
for some injection-molded Here-and-Now.

Now, look across the freeway -
see that purple awning flappin' in the breeze?
That's Momma Genuine's shop.
She's older than all of us put together
but she still laughs like a house.
She only sells tools, but not like you know.

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She's got saws that put back together,
an' drills that make whole.
Momma's a good legend to know,
and she sells duct tape too.

And down there, at the end of the block,
are two kids - crewcut and pigtails -
sittin' behind a vinyl-topped table
sellin' peanut butter ice cream out of a galvanized pail.
There's no metaphor there – it's just good ice cream,
and that's all it has to be.

So here's what you do:
Take a look around,
pick out what reminds you of places you wanted to be,
but gave up on goin'
and jam it all in this big box called "Now."
Then go across the street to Momma Genuine's;
ask her how she's been,
show her what I gave ya, and she'll know

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exactly what you need.
Then go back in the center of that freeway,
keepin' faith in the traffic jam swerve,
and get to work
makin' it all fit.
You won't have any directions or
factory number tabs, but don't panic.
See, there's a hunnerd ways to do it right, and none
to do it wrong, so you can't do any worse.
Use the tools Momma gave you,
hum a little while you work,
and if you find yourself sproutin' extra thumbs,
take a break. Go down the block. Get yourself an ice cream.
Smile when they hand it to you,
tip 'em if you can, and when you get back . . .

it'll all make sense!
You'll see where it's gonna fit perfect, and
where the duct tape has to go.
When you get finished, take whatever spare parts

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you've got at the bottom of Now,
make yourself a little sign that says "Tomorrow"
and hang it on your masterpiece.

Then I want you to go back down the block
to where those two kids are packing up their
peanut butter enterprise
'cause somebody told them they'd fail
and I want you to hand them Tomorrow.
Make sure they know how important it is.
And after they've run off with it all
elbows and smiles
you come back here, an' we'll do it all over again.

Now, I'm not telling you this to make a profit.
That's how so many good ideas go wrong.
I'm jus' tired of seeing everyday people
streamin' through these doors convinced
they gotta hock even their littlest hopes and dreams
to fund their 401Ks.
I'm tired of seeing this whole world being bent on

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Going Big or givin' up,
only handin' out glory
to newspaper headlines and storybook endings,
'cause the truth is:
I think we need those swing sets most on the cloudy
days.
I'm happy goin' to sleep after
"just" a goodnight kiss
If it made me feel somethin' inside,
and I believe that beauty can be as simple
as two kids - crewcut and pigtails -
handin' me a scoop of peanut butter ice cream
that tastes so good,
you'd think it was a dream.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

*Author: Eric Darby*
*Book: High Desert Voices: The 2005 National Poetry Slam Anthology*
*ISBN: 978-1893972834*
*Publisher: The Wordsmith Press*
*Date (Month/Year): 2006*

## AWARD HISTORY

*2009 National Qualifier*
*MN State Qualifier*

### Angelic Insanity (or, The Ninja Ponies Poem) by Kevin "Chesko" Brianesco

Down to the crooked teeth,

chubby cheeks<

and s-s-s-stutter

My Godson Carlitos,

Is a three-foot version of me.

And as I watch him digging a hole in the backyard,

I remember back when I was a little boy -

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My grandmother would tell me,

"If you can dig a deep enough hole

You can see the sunrise at night."

But no matter how many holes I dug

And no matter how deep I was able to go -

The sun kept setting.

And eventually I stopped digging -

Understanding the futility of seeing something as absurd

as the sun rising at night.

On cue,

My Godson stumbles over to me and says,

"Nino, when I grow up,

I'm gonna be a pony!"

And I smile -

Trying to hid the fact that

I want to grab him and

I want to shake some sense into him -

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Tell him that he can't be a pony,
that the piece of the Easter bunny's tail
we caught in our Easter bunny trap
is really just a dirty piece of cotton,
That mommy's special friend,
"Uncle Steve"
Isn't really his uncle
And that the sun -
won't ever rise at night.
But as I sat there contemplating his fate
I noticed something in his eyes that I had never seen
before.
And all I could do was watch as his eyes
began refracting the starlight from the windows,
like prisms,
into a million tiny promises
that his gaze -
would never reflect my own.

And, in the moment of angelic insanity,
I told him -

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"I'm gonna be a pony too!"

Only I told him that we would be ninja ponies,
ninja crime-fighting ponies -
who can fly!
and we will call ourselves Pony Joe
and Johnny Nintendo
because people will write comic books about us!

Apparently he was satisfied with my answer
Because he decided to change the subject -
And asked me to tell him a story before he went to
sleep.
You see, he sees me as his Nino,
his hero,
One of the few remaining fantasies I have left that still
keeps me going.
So I resist,
not wanting to disappoint these angel eyes,
But after enough begging,
I gave in and told him a story

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About a little boy [child/girl]

about his age,

Who grew up to be a pony

that once dug a hole so deep -

s/he was able to see the sunrise at night.

Without hesitation,

He just looked up at me and asked,

"So how deep did you have to dig, Nino?"

then started spinning around in circles

Look, I know that eventually my Godson's imagination will

fade

and that I'm not going to be his hero forever,

but on that night

in the eyes of this tiny little man,

I was a pony,

and he wanted to be me -

and as I looked out the window into the moonlit sky,

I swear to God,

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I saw the sun begin to rise.

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